Preliminary Explorations in the Karbi Langpi Valley, Karbi Anglong District, Assam with Special Emphasis on the Ceramics

Nisha Rani Das[1]

1. Department of Archaeology and Ancient History, The Maharaja Sayajirao University of Baroda, Vadodara- 390 002, Gujarat, India (*Email: nisha89das@gmail.com)*

Received: 18 August 2019; Revised: 27 September 2019; Accepted: 25 October 2019
Heritage: Journal of Multidisciplinary Studies in Archaeology 7 (2019): 670-678

Abstract: *The pottery tradition of Assam seems to be in continuity from Neolithic period to Medieval through a flourishing stage of Early Historic period with very little variation. The earliest date goes back to 2.7±0.3 Ka from Daojali Hading (Neolithic site) and Early Historic site Ambari has been relatively dated to 2nd century B.C to 1st century AD. The present explorations at three sites i.e. Bichikkri, Langmet and Kekang-Adong in the Karbi Langpi river valley, western Karbi-Anglong district of Assam, have yielded good number of archaeological evidences, especially ceramics. This paper addresses the difficulty of placing the cultural material of the region into proper chronology as similar assemblages are continuing for a very long period. The problems regarding the fabric and raw materials of the ceramics among the explored sites of same river valley still persist. The main objective of the paper is to study the material remains and to understand their association with neighboring areas in terms of inter and intra-site relationship. The study of ceramics from the three sites has been divided into two groups: group A and group B in terms of its fabric and the use of Kaolin clay as raw material for making the vessels and at times to decorate them. The explored material has been placed chronologically in Early Historic period after comparing them with those from excavated sites (Ambari, Sarutaru, Marakdola and Daojali Hading) from Assam.*

Keywords: Karbi-Langpi, Mikir Hill, Karbi-Anglong, Assam, Pottery, Early-Historic, Kaolin Clay

Introduction

The earliest culture in Assam begins with the Neolithic period through the findings of cord impressed pottery and stone tools such as Celts, Adzes, and Axes etc from important excavated sites; such as, Daojali Hading (Sharma, 1966) and Sarutaru (Rao 1977). Daojali Hading has given the earliest date of 2.7±0.3Ka (Sharma and Singh 2017). This is supposedly a very late date if we compare with other Indian sites from other regions; Lahuradeva (Tewari et.al.2001) and Koldihawa (Sharma et.al.1980) whose dates go back 6th to 5th millennium B.C This Neolithic culture is succeeded by Early Historic period, with Ambari being one of the significant Early Historic site in Assam

tentatively dated to 2nd century BC to 1st century AD (Sengupta and Sharma 2011). Interestingly the cord marked pottery, the typical Neolithic pottery of Assam and adjoining regions continue to occur in Early Historic period with slight variations in fabric and raw materials. Moreover, the contemporary pottery tradition of Assam owes its origin to the Neolithic period, passing through a flourishing stage in the Mediaeval period and still continuing among the Hira potters and Kumhars (Medhi 1992). The present explored sites in the Karbi Langpi valley, Karbi-Anglong district have yielded good quantity of potsherds from surface survey.

Aims and Objectives

The ceramics collected from the Karbi Langpi valley are similar in appearance to pottery assemblages from Neolithic to Mediaeval period. Thus, the problem of placing the present assemblage from the explored sites in the chronology on the basis of fabric, raw material and decorations is persisting. The aim of the present paper is to address this issue. The main objective is to study the material remains from Karbi Langpi river valley to understand its association with neighbouring areas. The present explored materials have some similarities with Neolithic as well as Early Historic period ceramics in terms of fabric and decorations. It is an attempt to understand the cultural affiliation of the materials and inter and intra-site relationship.

Methods of Study

As this is a preliminary study, simple methodology was adopted. Initially previous literature review was done along with personal communication with the experts who have worked previously in the region. This was followed by Village to village survey in the present study area. Cultural materials were collected through random sampling method. After the field survey, the author studied the explored material and re-examined the already explored and excavated materials. Typological and chronological pottery charts from different excavated sites of Assam were prepared. A comparative study of ceramics from the current exploration was attempted with documentation in the form of drawing and photography.

Study Area

The study area covers the part of western Karbi-Anglong district that includes the Hamren and Baithalangshu sub-division. The area is bounded by Jaintia hills in the west, North Cachar hills in the south, Mikir hills in the east that is an extension of Meghalayan plateau and Nagaon district of Assam in the North. The area is drained by two main rivers i.e. Karbi Langpi or Borapani and Kopili River. The sites that have been explored are mainly in the valley of Karbi Langpi, that originates from Jaintia hills and enters Karbi-Anglong just below its confluence with Umlew river (Dutta 1979). Karbi Langpi in its upper reaches is known as Umkhen and as the source of the river lies in a region of heavy precipitation, it brings down a high discharge, while passing through the low-lying areas it spills copiously right from the foothills. As it floods it also holds up the Kopili flood on the upstream and tremendously affects the

Baithalangshu area (Dutta 1979). The elevation of the entire area ranges from 10 m to 1000 m AMSL. The rocks available within the nearby areas are mainly sandstone and granite. The area has good vegetation cover which comprises of wild berries, gomari (*Gmelina arborea*), rohimola (*Garuga pinnata*), Leteku (*Baccaurea ramiflora*), Silikha (*Terminalia chebula*) and Bamboo. People mainly depend on jhum and step cultivation with the important crops being rice, brum, ginger, turmeric, sesame and chilly. The entire land is hilly where plateaus and slopes are mainly used for cultivation. The soil is red loamy with some patches of brown soil.

Earlier studies in this particular area are meagre in Prehistoric and Early Historic context, though frequent investigations of Megalithic remains have been attempted by the Archaeological Survey of India, Guwahati circle (Personal communication with Salam Shyam Singh). As a part of doctoral research Senar Robinson of Gauhati University explored few sites i.e Bichikkri, Dikisir, Moring Morong and collected material remains such as pottery and stone tools. A trial trench at Bichikkri yielded potsherds and stone artifacts. A comparative study of Bichikkri and Dikisir material with the materials from Daojali Hading, Selbalgiri, Sarutaru Marakdola and Ambari was also attempted (Senar 2016). Senar after comparing the pottery with all the previously mentioned sites, put forward an observation that "Bichikkri site embodies a cultural phase that stand out as a continuum of Neolithic tradition through prehistoric ages to the historic times".



Figure 1: Location of Explored sites (Courtesy: Google earth)

Explored Sites

Along with the previously studied site of Bichikkri (25^0 57′ 52.6″ N and 092^0 30′ 25.3″ E), two other sites were newly explored i.e Kekang-Adong (25^{0}58′57.4″ N and 092^{0}36′05.3″ E) and Langmet (25° 53.935′ N, 092° 34.222′ E) (Figure 1). The former two sites are near Baithalangshu and later is in Hamren.

Bichikkri

The site is located in the village Bichikkri at an elevation of 449 m ASL and is surrounded by Baithalangshu in the north and Hamren sub-divison of Karbi-Anglong

district in the south, while on its west lies the Jaintia hills of Meghalaya and river Karbi Langpi in the east. The nearest water source is Karbi Langpi river. The entire land is hilly while plateaus and slopes are mainly used for cultivation. The present population choose to occupy high-altitude area, 2 to 3 km away from the main river valley. It may be observed that the distribution pattern of most of the earlier explored sites of North-east India are from hilly areas and the cultivable land is on the slope of hills. This might be because of the shifting cultivation tradition and to remain secure from the highly flooded river (Hazarika 2006). The soil colour of this particular area is reddish and loamy in nature.

The site yielded mostly Red Wares (Figure 2). There are several variants of red colour ranging from brown to dark-reddish brown and bright red brown. These are mostly handmade as identified by Senar. The cores of the sherds vary from black to grey suggesting low firing. Both slipped and non-slipped potsherds were recovered. The shapes include bowl, cooking vessel, basins with a round bottom, platter etc (Senar 2016). The fabric of most of the potsherds is coarse to very coarse with sandy texture and rim sherds have well marked carination on its shoulder. However, the potsherds are devoid of any design on its external surface.



Figure 2: Potsherds from Bichikkri (after Senar 2016)

Kekang Adong

This site is in village Ranhabaigaon of Baithalangshu sub-division and is at an elevation of 66m MSL. This site is currently an agricultural land, which extends for almost 1 km from one end to the other and is surrounded by Punja Hill in the north, Hamren in the south. River Karbi Langpi flows in eastern direction approximately 1 km from the site. A stream, Narlokadong, also flows close to the site. The main agricultural crops cultivated in this area include mustard, rice and sesame. Soil is

brown in colour. The area falls under flood plain of Karbi Langpi, which floods every year.

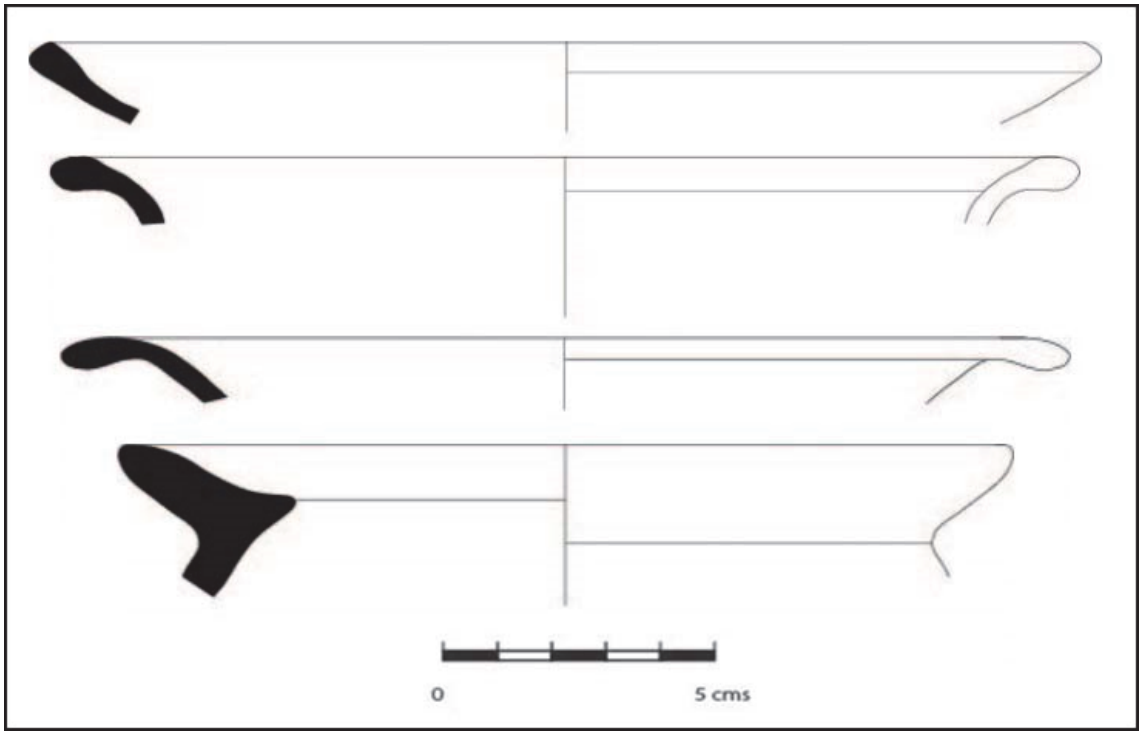


Figure 3: Potsherds collected from Kekang-Adong

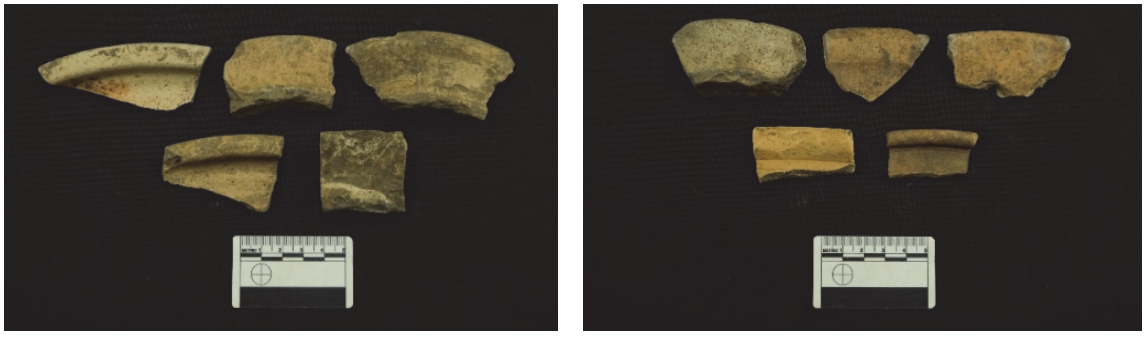


Figure 4: Rim sherds from Kekang-Adong

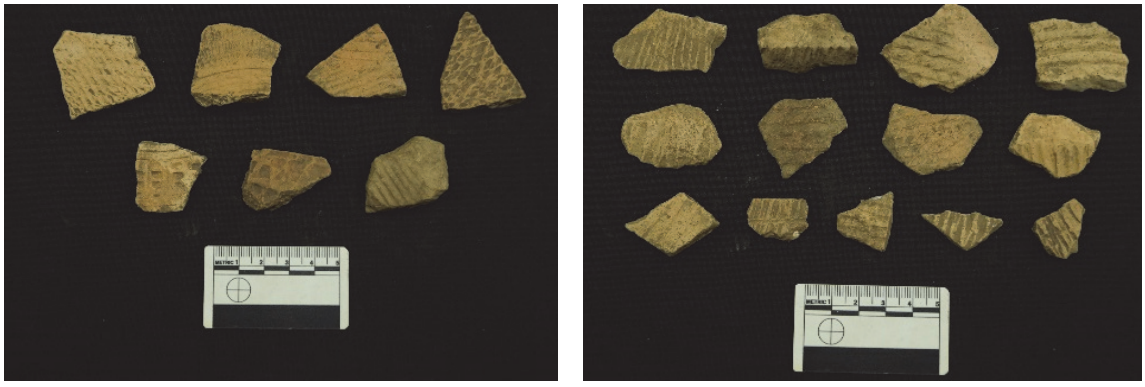


Figure 5: Decorated body sherds from Kekang-Adong

The material evidence available here is mostly ceramics (Figures 3 and 4). Although the locals claim finding of stone tools (such as celt and adzes) in recent past during the cultivation, no such material was found during the present exploration. The surface collection of pottery includes mainly Red and Buff ware. The ceramics appear to be both hand and wheel made and contain shiny mica particles in the clay. Medium to low firing has been observed. The core of most of the pot sherds are not fully oxidized and, in some samples, the core of the pottery is completely blackish. The fabric of potteries is mostly fine. A good number of potsherds are made of Kaolin clay and have slip on exterior surface. The vessel forms are mostly pot and platter with out-turned, flaring rim and thickened interior. The designs include cord or basket impressions, strokes are vertical and horizontal, criss-cross lines, parallel bands, incisions and nail impressions (Figure 5).

Langmet

The site is near Hamren sub-division. The site elevation is 471 m MSL. The area nearby is hilly with dense vegetation cover and soil is loamy red. This particular area was chosen for field survey as some stone tools were discovered by the local habitants during their jhum cultivation in nearby fields. A number of potsherds have been collected from the section of a road cutting area where the soil is yellowish red. The pottery has similarity with the ceramics of Bichikkri. A few potsherds have been recovered and the condition of the pottery is very fragile and abraded (Figure 6). Most sherds are of Red ware with very coarse fabric variety. The rim sherds found are mainly of pot with short neck. No designs were observed on any of the potsherds from this site.

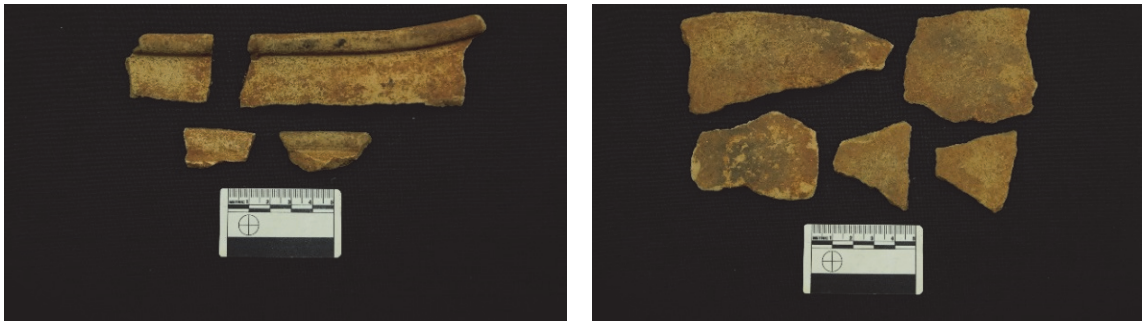


Figure 6: Potsherds from Langmet

Discussion and Conclusion

After the study of cultural material, it has been observed that among the three explored sites, the pottery assemblages of Bichikkri and Langmet are almost similar in terms of its fabric (coarse to medium fine), surface treatment (devoid of any decoration) and shapes, whereas the potsherds of Kekang-Adong has different fabric (fine), surface treatment (decorations) and shapes. The ceramics from these sites are divided into two groups i.e Group A (Bichikkri, Langmet) and group B (Kekang-Adong). Distinction between the two groups is that all the pottery found from group A is Red ware. Group B pottery has both Red and Buff ware (Kaolin clay) as its constituent where the

percentage of Buff being higher. The use of Kaolin clay is prominent in Group B. Group A sites are located in the hilly areas near Karbi Langpi river valley where the soil content is red loamy, while group B site is in alluvium plain of the same river valley and soil content varies from greyish to brownish. It probably signifies the use of available raw materials for the manufacture of pottery from the immediate vicinity.

The assemblages found from Bichikkri is correlated with the assemblages found from different sites of Assam and other North eastern states belonging to different cultural periods. According to Senar (2016) there is a close similarity in fabric and in methods of firing within the ceramics from Daojali Hading and Selbalgiri, which are reported from Neolithic sites in this broader region. This similarity is also based on slip application and outer profile. The ceramics are devoid of any impression. Correspondingly the Bichikkri pottery exhibit similarity in certain attributes with the pottery from Marakdola, a post-Neolithic site (Rao. 1977) and Ambari, an Early Historic site (Sharma *et al.* 1994). The shapes and carination on the pottery seems to be similar to Ambari pottery which is a typical ware of the site. On the basis of the fabric and shapes, Bichikkri cultural period is relatively dated to Early Historic (Senar 2016).

The correlation of the group B potsherds is again done with the already established Neolithic and Early Historic sites of Assam. The potteries of Neolithic Daojali Hading has cord or basket impression and paddle marks but those are low fired, have coarse fabric and are grey in colour. Majority of the ceramics are handmade. Due to the absence of diagnostic sherds it is difficult to figure out the shapes of the pottery.

The pottery assemblages of Saruataru and Marakdola has both cord and paddle impressions but its fabric is different from that of Daojali Hading. It has a finer fabric in comparison to the latter and its colour varies from brown, buff to grey (Rao, 1977). The potteries are mostly wheel turned and made with fine kaolin clay. Sarutaru pottery assemblages have patterns like cord impressions, hearing bone patterns and zig zag designs. Moreover, Marakdola pottery shapes are mainly globular jars, bowls and dishes. Rao (1977) assigned the dates of these sites to Neolithic and Post-Neolithic respectively, however, the only sample dated using radio carbon methods gave it a date as modern (Possehl 1988), probably due to a sampling error. Later, Sharma (2012) explored the area and found Mediaeval pottery and no celts and cord-impresses potteries were reported. The potteries of Marakdola has many similarities with Ambari (Early Historic) in its fabric, firing and designs; cord or paddle impressions, medium net, parallel bands etc.

Ambari assemblages have developed ware type and mostly are made of Kaolin clay with fine fabric and texture. Both hand and wheel turned potteries are present in the assemblage. Colour of potsherds varied from red to buff (Sharma *et al.* 1994) and their decorations vary from cord or mat impressions, paddle marks, ribbed pattern, crossed designs, parallel bands and cross design and vessel shapes are globular jars, dishes, and lotas, which are similar to Marakdola.

The continuity of fabric, designs and shapes from earlier culture is evident from these researches. The group B assemblages has similarity with many of the excavated sites of Assam that has a time range from Neolithic to Early historic period but have affinities with Early historic pottery assemblages of Ambari in terms of its fabric, decorations and most importantly, the application of Kaolin clay. Most of the sherds are globular pots/jars and a few shallow vessels such as dish or platter.

Karbi Langpi river valley falls in the Mikir hill district of Assam and its geography is different from Brahmaputra valley, but the cultural material is similar. If we consider the use of Kaolin clay as raw material and the similar designs in Early Historic period from the site of Ambari, the site Kekang-Adong (group B) can be placed in the comparable time period, which is early Historic. On the other hand, the assemblages from Langmet (group A) can be placed within the period similar to Bichikkri which is again mentioned as an Early Historic site (Senar 2016). Although there are differences between explored assemblages of these two groups, it is difficult to separate them in two different categories on the basis of exploration at this stage. Further scientific studies might resolve this issue. The author proposes to pursue this research in near future and address the problem of ceramics and their cultural affinities in this region.

Acknowledgements

Acknowledgement is due to many. The author is thankful to Prof. K. Krishnan for his immense support and guidance. Special thanks to Mr. Longsing Ronpipi and Ms. Tunika for their immense help during the field survey in Karbi Anglong. I am also grateful to Ms. Rajalakshmi, Ms. Navjot and Mr. Jayendra for valuable suggestions for the improvement of the paper.

References

A Source Book of the Archaeology of Assam and Other States of North Eastern India. 1984. Guwahati: Kamarupa Anusandhana Samiti in collaboration with IAS, ISPQS and IHCS.

Allen, B. C., E. A. Gait, C. G. H. Allen and H. F. Howard. 2012. *Gazetteer of Bengal and North-East India*. Delhi: A Mittal Publication.

Ansari, Z. D and M. K. Dhavalikar. 1970. Excavations at Ambari, Guwahati: 1970. *Ambari Archaeological Site: An Interim Report*. H. N. Dutt. (Ed.). Pp. 12-16. Guwahati: Directorate of Archaeology Assam.

Choudhury, R. D. 1985. *Archaeology of the Brahmaputra Valley of Assam (Pre-Ahom Period)*. Delhi: Agam Kala Prakashan.

Dikshit, K. N. and M. Hazarika. 2012. The Neolithic Cultures of Northeast India and Adjoining Regions: A Comparative Study. *Journal of Indian Ocean Archaeology* 7: 98-148.

Dutt, K. N. 1979. *Gazetteer of India-Assam State. U.M and N.C Hills Districts (Karbi-Anglong and North Cachar Hill Districts)*. Assam: Government of Assam.

Goswami, M. C. and S. K. Roy. A Report on Selected Potsherds from Ambari, Archaeological Site. *Ambari Archaeological Site: An Interim Report*. H. N. Dutt. (Ed.). Pp. 27-29. Guwahati: Directorate of Archaeology Assam.

Hazarika, M. 2006. Neolithic Culture of Northeast India: A Recent Perspective on the Origins of Pottery and Agriculture, *Ancient Asia* 1: 25-43.

Imperial Gazetteer of India: Provincial Series Eastern Bengal and Assam. 1909. Calcutta: Superintendent of Government Printing.

Medhi, B. 1992. *The Potters and Pottery of Nalbari District, Assam: A Study in Ethnohistory and Ethnoarchaeology*. Unpublished PhD Thesis. Guwahati: Gauhati University.

Possehl, G. L. 1988. Radiocarbon Dates from South Asia. *Man and Environment* 12: 169-96.

Rao, S. N. 1977. Continuity and Survival of Neolithic Traditions in Northeastern India. *Asian Perspectives* XX (2): 191-205.

Roy, S. K. 1977. *A Study of Ceramics from Neolithic to Mediaval period of Assam: An Ethno-Archaeological Approach.* Unpublished PhD Thesis. Guwahati: Gauhati University.

Senar, R. 2016. *Neolithic Traditions in West Karbi-Anglong, Assam*. Unpublished PhD Thesis. Guwahati: Gauhati University.

Sengupta, G. and S. Sharma. 2011. Archaeology in North-East India: The Post-Independence Scenario. *Ancient India*. *New Series No*.1: 353-368.

Sharma, G. R., V. D. Misra, D. Mandal, B. B. Misran and J. N. Pal. 1980. *Beginnings of Agriculture*. Allahabad: Abhinav Prakashan.

Sharma, H. C. 2012. Prehistoric Archaeology of North-East India. T. B. Subba (ed.). *North-East India: A Handbook of Anthropology.* New Delhi: Orient Blackswan Private Limited.

Sharma, H. C., A. A. Ashraf and H. C. Mahanta. 1994. Ceramic Tradition in Brahmaputra Valley, Assam: A Case Study from Ambari, Guwahati, cited in Ambari Archaeological Site. *Ambari Archaeological Site: An Interim Report*. H. N. Dutt. (Ed.). Pp. 45-50. Guwahati: Directorate of Archaeology Assam.

Sharma, S. and P. Singh. 2017. Luminescence Dating of Neolithic pottery in North East India. *Current Science* 113 (3): 492-496.

Sharma, T. C. 1966. *Prehistoric Archaeology of Assam- A Study of the Neolithic Culture.* Unpublished PhD Thesis. London: University of London.

Tewari, R, R. K. Srivastava, K. S. Saraswat, I. B. Singh and K. K. Singh. 2008. Early Farming at Lahuradewa. *Pragdhara* 18: 347-373.